

How CEOs balance workouts with workloads

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The 5am workout has become something of a ritual for many chief executives — or so they claim.

Bosses often like to promote their physical fitness regime as a central part of their daily schedule, as important as any business meeting. Exercise is regarded as a way to build stamina and discipline, to improve cognitive function, to recharge and reduce stress. One study even found a positive link between CEO fitness and the value of their company.

But how easy is it to balance workouts with workloads? Top executives tell the FT how they do it.

Roland Busch, chief executive, Siemens

Busch takes his workouts seriously and wants to make one thing clear: he does not skip leg day.

The Siemens chief executive's early morning workout is a fixed part of his schedule, even when travelling, and one he says holds "the same importance as any business meeting".

A trained physicist, who has led the German industry and infrastructure group since 2021, Busch starts his day at 6am with a mix of weight training and high-intensity exercises.

The 61-year-old's routine is organised into three days — chest and abs, back and legs, and abs and core — that follow in a loop. The regime allows time for each part of the body to recover, allowing Busch to maintain his workout habit without burning out.

"I see a direct link between my physical fitness and my professional performance. The discipline and energy I gain from my workouts are crucial for managing a demanding schedule," he says.

As chief executive, Busch has progressed Siemens's transition from an unwieldy conglomerate into a leaner technology-driven operation. He has integrated artificial intelligence into industry — and also into his fitness regime, sharing an AI-generated comic book strip depicting his routines on [LinkedIn](#) to help motivate others. *Sebastien Ash*

Sayeh Ghanbari, head of consulting, EY

Ghanbari could probably decimate you without breaking a sweat. The EY consulting boss has won multiple medals at the British Nationals for her practice of kung fu.

She trains in sessions that last well over two hours, three times a week, and has risen to become a senior black belt. She is also an assistant teacher, an honour awarded after facing five men in an open-hand sparring match.

Ghanbari is clear about needing to make space during her professional life for her love of martial arts and says the two are “synergistic”. “Fundamentally kung fu is a continuous improvement art, it is mastery that you never ever complete so you always just have to refine. I could see that training in kung fu was helping me in my work.”

She has often told colleagues she needs to leave work to go to a class “and if I need to I can pick up my laptop again after”. While travelling, she has joined classes through Skype, sometimes “at really odd time differences . . . that’s the discipline”.

Ghanbari says the practice has helped her deal with conflict. “In kung fu you block a straight punch with a circular block, so you don’t meet the force . . . with the same kind of force . . . Over time . . . you learn that when you get conflict you don’t meet it directly, you find a way of going around it.”

It has also taught humility and respect. “So it is about fighting but you do it . . . with humility. That almost contradiction I think creates something special.” *Ellesheva Kissin*

Michael Murray, chief executive, Frasers

The head of UK retail chain Frasers Group has always been obsessed with sport, trying everything from rugby and athletics to cross-country and boxing at school.

But as he got older he found it harder “to find a sport you can actually compete in apart from running races”. That is when he discovered Hyrox, an indoor fitness competition that combines 8km of running with exercises such as lunges and weights.

“I loved how measurable it was; you set targets and track progress . . . I’ve always been motivated by challenges that demand sustained discipline rather than quick wins, and Hyrox provides a constant benchmark against yourself.”

Murray can usually be found in the gym at 6.15am or running at 7am, and will train six days a week. Travel can shift his routine but he sets aside time for training, “in the same way I would any other important commitment”.

Most sessions last 60 to 90 minutes, although at weekends they can be longer. Murray ran the London Marathon in April and he and his partner competed in the Hyrox World Championships in Stockholm this month.

He says Hyrox makes him sharper and more focused. “High-intensity training is a great outlet and helps reset both mentally and physically. There are a lot of parallels with business as well — setting goals, having a clear plan, and staying consistent — which is why it’s such a natural fit.” *Philip Stafford*

Kevin O’Brien, chief executive of Gammon Construction

Two mornings a week O’Brien, chief executive of Jardine Matheson and Balfour Beatty-owned Gammon Construction, can be found barrelling down Bowen Road, one of Hong Kong Island’s flattest and most scenic running routes. As a construction chief executive in charge of Hong Kong airport’s Terminal 2 and an economic development project in Hong Kong’s New Territories, he starts work early and is up even earlier to hit the tarmac before meetings.

“Construction is an early industry so I’m up at 6 or even earlier.” The key to fitting exercise into a busy schedule is simple: “Get [it] done straight away.”

O’Brien was not a serious runner until he turned 40, when he “started to think a lot harder about how to take care of my physical health”.

Now he runs an average of three times per week, including two morning runs of around 10km and a longer route along the harbour front at weekends. On work trips, he makes sure to pack running shoes to take in a new city.

The greatest benefits for him are clear headspace and an easing of work and life pressures. This year his first full marathon was Hong Kong’s Standard Chartered race in January. As a child in the 1980s, he fondly remembers volunteering to hand out water bottles to London Marathon runners — next year he hopes to do it himself. *Arjun Neil Alim*



Becky Worthington, outgoing chief financial officer, Canary Wharf Group

On a recent Thursday evening, Worthington was heading off to a skiffing, or wooden rowing boat, lesson. That was followed by two triathlons on Saturday and Sunday and a swim relay on Monday. “This is an unusual weekend,” she says, although she admits she is a “habitual trainer” who exercises every day.

The chief financial officer of Canary Wharf Group, which oversees the east London financial district, grew up running and dancing and joined the University Officers’ Training Corps, a British Army Reserve unit.

The now 54-year-old did her first triathlon when she was 40 and competes in three a year. She maintains her routine year-round: getting to the gym by 7am, before anything workwise has “blown up”, and doing 45 minutes to an hour of cycling, running, swimming and weights. On weekends, she runs outside and swims in a river.

During races, Worthington has noticed a difference between male and female competitors. When a woman “accidentally kicks you, they put their head above the water and say, ‘oh,

sorry,' and carry on," she says. [But a man would] use you as a lever to accelerate. They push you down and under the water, so they can get further ahead more quickly."

She will leave her role on December 31 and plans to spend retirement ski mountaineering and cross-country skiing in the French Alps and sailing the Mediterranean. *Julie Steinberg*

Christoph Jurecka, chief executive, Munich Re

During a business trip to Mumbai, Jurecka found himself practising yoga after work with colleagues just a short distance from Munich Re's local office. For the chief executive of the world's largest reinsurer, it was a memorable opportunity to practise in yoga's country of origin — and the latest chapter in a passion that began more than a decade ago.

For Jurecka, yoga and insurance serve a similar purpose: building resilience. Insurance helps society absorb shocks and recover from setbacks, while yoga strengthens the body and mind to better deal with challenges.

Today, he favours Ashtanga yoga, a physically demanding style that emphasises the synchronisation of posture, breathing and focus. The intensity is part of the attraction. "It keeps me physically and mentally fit," he says. "At the same time, you learn to test the boundaries of what is possible."

At home, Jurecka often starts the day on his yoga mat and prefers sessions intense enough to leave little room for thoughts about the day ahead. "After a demanding practice, I can begin the day feeling balanced."

Yoga's flexibility also suits travelling. He takes a mat on business trips and holidays, allowing him to practise almost anywhere. *Florian Mueller*

James McMaster, chief executive, Huel

For a chief executive of a company whose core consumers are protein-maxxing gym bros, the Huel boss has a surprisingly varied regime. "Squeezing exercise in as a CEO and parent of young kids can be tough. I'm a big planner, though," says McMaster.

He exercises according to heart rate "zones", which indicate how hard your heart works and what your body is burning for fuel. His optimal is zone 2, which is best for building endurance and burning fat.

McMaster trains with weights three to four mornings a week, and sometimes fits a session "into a random gap, like 3pm". Twice a week, he takes a 20-minute sauna. And on Monday nights he joins Huel colleagues for a game of football.

He has a static exercise bike in the garden shed and a weighted backpack in his car, for impromptu “rucking”. “I’ll whack it on if I’m walking the dog or with the kids . . . It roughly doubles calorie burn versus regular walking, gives you some zone 2, and strengthens your core, back and legs — all while doing something you’d be doing anyway.”

“Exercise helps me clear my head,” McMaster says. “I feel more in control and positive when I’m in a good spot physically. And I think I get more work done.” *Madeleine Speed*

Arlo Brady, chief executive, Freuds Group

After a few years as chief executive of the British communications group Freuds, Brady noticed the slightest hint of a stomach bulge on a wiry frame that had always fitted into the clothes he wore at university.

“Before 45 I think I was pretty mentally resilient and I guess my metabolism must have been operating at a different level, and I don’t think I necessarily noticed the fact that this role was taking a toll on me,” he says. “It’s terrific fun, but it’s super intensive.”

Brady, 48, hates the gym. Instead he started using weeknights at home to lift weights and do 6km workouts on a rowing machine. He also kept up his love of sailing, cycling, playing padel, and rowing on the Thames in Oxford. To help hit 10,000 steps a day, he bought an Australian Labradoodle and held walking meetings.

A few years into these lifestyle changes, Brady damaged his knee in a skiing accident in Italy and then had a pulmonary embolism on the drive home through Switzerland. Now he is focused on rehabilitation exercises, electrical muscle stimulation, sleep and hydration. “I’m just going to have to slowly build back up.” *Kenza Bryan*

Joanne Crevoiserat, chief executive, Tapestry

The head of the New York-based fashion company that owns the brands Coach, Kate Spade and Stuart Weitzman, made a promise to herself during the pandemic that she would run every day. She kept it up for years, sometimes clocking just one mile to keep the streak alive. Once business travel started again — meaning red-eye flights that made the 6am effort impossible — the streak was finally broken. But Crevoiserat still tries to get out most mornings, and when travelling for work seeks out hotels with good gyms. “It has to happen early (usually 6am) because it is impossible to find the time later in the day.”

She says even “30 to 45 minutes gives me renewed energy and the space to think, work through challenges and often unlock new ideas.”

She adds strength training to her workouts two to three days a week with a personal trainer whom she often meets virtually “because we are typically in different cities”.

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GEMINI Summary

Based on the article, top executives view physical fitness not as a distraction, but as a critical driver of professional stamina, discipline, and mental clarity.

Here is how these leaders structure their routines to balance heavy workloads:

Early Morning Consistency

- **Roland Busch (Siemens):** Starts at 6:00 AM with a structured three-day lifting and high-intensity loop. He treats workouts with the same importance as business meetings.
- **Michael Murray (Frasers Group):** Trains six days a week at 6:15 AM or 7:00 AM, focusing on Hyrox (indoor fitness racing) and running to reset mentally.
- **Joanne Crevoiserat (Tapestry):** Prioritizes a 6:00 AM window for running and virtual strength training to ensure it gets done before the day becomes unpredictable.
- **Kevin O'Brien (Gammon Construction):** Runs 10km sessions before early morning construction meetings to clear his head.

Integration and Flexibility

- **Sayeh Ghanbari (EY Consulting):** A senior black belt in kung fu who trains over two hours, three times a week. She explicitly sets boundaries to leave work for class, catching up on tasks later if needed.
- **James McMaster (Huel):** Fits weight training into random calendar gaps, plays football with colleagues, and uses a weighted backpack for "rucking" while walking his dog or spending time with his kids.
- **Christoph Jurecka (Munich Re):** Practices intense Ashtanga yoga to build personal resilience, packing a travel mat so he can maintain his routine on global business trips.

Adaptability Through Setbacks

- **Becky Worthington (Canary Wharf Group):** A daily habitual trainer who competes in multiple triathlons. She focuses on early morning gym sessions before work "blows up" and plans to pivot to alpine sports in retirement.
- **Arlo Brady (Freuds Group):** Turned to rowing and weight training to combat a demanding lifestyle, and is currently adapting his routine to focus on rehabilitation following a major skiing injury.